

Reigniting Canadian Space Exploration: A Feasible Mid-Power Plan

A practical agenda for the Canadian Space Agency and Government of Canada

Canada is not a lost cause. It already punches above its weight on robotics, Earth observation, and ESA partnerships. What is missing is not talent—it is a sharper national bet and steadier funding. The path forward is specialization, multi-year envelopes, and exportable Canadian hardware, not an attempt to copy NASA's full stack.

Six Recommendations

1. Pick three missions, not twenty.

Double down on Canadarm-class robotics and on-orbit servicing; Arctic and ocean Earth observation (climate, ice, shipping); and a focused lunar/cislunar contribution (rover, instruments, or logistics) so Canadian firms stay in Artemis and ESA supply chains.

2. Fund like infrastructure.

Place multi-year envelopes in the fiscal framework—not annual scramble—with clear milestones for CSA, NRC, and industry. Aim for a credible floor near peer mid-powers: roughly 0.05–0.1% of GDP over a decade, ramped, not a one-year splash.

3. Build a Canadian prime path.

Require that major contracts leave intellectual property and exportable products in Canada. Use public procurement to grow a few export champions in robotics, sensors, small satellites, and ground systems—rather than only buying foreign buses.

4. Use ESA and NASA as amplifiers.

Keep the Canada–ESA agreement, but demand Canadian lead roles on chosen instruments and missions. Treat U.S. and commercial partners the same way: contribute unique hardware, not just cash or flags.

5. Grow people where the work is.

Expand co-ops and clearances with universities across Quebec, Ontario, the Prairies, and Atlantic Canada. Stand up one Arctic/space data hub—including an Atlantic Canada option such as Charlottetown—tied to real CSA data products so talent does not only cluster in Montreal.

6. Measure what matters.

Publish yearly: Canadian content on flown missions, export revenue, STEM placements, and Arctic/ocean data users. Kill programs that do not move those numbers.

Bottom line: Canada can reignite exploration by specializing hard, funding steadily, and selling world-class subsystems. That is a feasible mid-power plan—credible to allies, useful to industry, and measurable for taxpayers.

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